chief Ashwani Sharma as working president—a dual arrangement rare in the BJP. Adding to the confusion, general secretary (organisation) Manthri Srinivasulu has opened a third axis, with state leaders often complaining that he convenes district meetings without consulting the core group. The lack of coordination was evident when assignments for Amit Shah's proposed Moga rally had to be withdrawn amid widespread resentment during a meeting in Chandigarh on February 15—ironically on the very day Khanna shared a stage with Badal.

Policy signals have further complicated the picture—from proposals related to Chandigarh's legislative status and reforms at Panjab University to the struggle to engage farm unions on Indo-US trade discussions. Since the 2020–21 farmer protests and the break with the Akali Dal, the BJP has yet to build an organisation capable of fine-tuning local decision-making.

Takeaways

- **The BJP's largely urban base continues to cap its reach in a state where rural consolidation decides power**
- **Gaps between central command and the state unit deepen the party's troubles**

An incident outside Parliament on February 4 offered a telling glimpse into this disconnect. When Congress leader Rahul Gandhi allegedly called Bittu a "traitor", the BJP framed the remark as an insult to Sikhs and lined up its community leaders in the former Congressman's defence—but almost all were from Delhi. The optics were stark: Delhi's Sikhs defending a Punjab leader while the state itself remained largely silent. Hardly surprising, since Bittu enjoys little popularity among rural Sikhs in Punjab. ■

▶ SIKKIM

ONE CHILD, ONE FOREST

A government scheme inviting people to plant 108 saplings in their child's name turns conservation into a shared public responsibility

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

MOHAN GAUTAM, 37, visits the plantation near Ani Monastery in Ranka, about 20 km from capital Gangtok, almost every month to ensure the 108 saplings he planted in the name of his elder son, Pranab, are thriving. He chose fruit-bearing trees, so that they may one day supplement the family's income. At nearby Reshithang, he has planted another 108 saplings for his younger son, Munna—flowering varieties that will change colour with the seasons.

Gautam's story is being replicated across Sikkim through the '*Mero Rukh, Mero Santati* (My Tree My Legacy)' initiative, which links the birth of a child to the planting of 108 trees in its name. Since its inception in February 2023, 9,234 newborns have been registered under the scheme, translating into 997,272 saplings on the ground. For a small Himalayan state with a sensitive ecology, the scale of this people-driven effort underscores the depth of personal responsibility it seeks to cultivate.

The idea, officials say, was never meant to be a routine plantation drive. Dr Pradeep Kumar, principal chief conservator of forests and secretary of the forest and environment department,

ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR



ROOTED REFORM A beneficiary with her child and saplings